**Why Did Waiting Times Increase in March 2026?**

Prepared by Ruchitha, For: Operations Director - Asterwell Health & Services Ltd (fictional data)

**Business Question**

The Operations Director asked why waiting times increased in March 2026. We agreed to compare March with February 2026, across all clinics, looking at both the average and the median waiting time.

**Data Used**

I used 14,480 clean appointment records from January 2025 to June 2026. The data was cleaned and validated first: 820 records were removed for quality reasons, such as duplicates and impossible dates. Waiting time is measured as the number of days from booking to appointment.

**Method**

I compared the average (mean) and median waiting times between February and March, and checked how many waits were over the 48-day target. I broke the change down by service and by clinic, and compared March with the previous 18 months to see whether it was unusual.

**Key Findings**

- The average wait rose from 17.0 to 18.3 days (+1.3), and the median from 14 to 15 days.
- Waits over 48 days rose from 18 to 33 (2.4% → 4.2%), crossing the 4% red threshold.
- The biggest change was in Physiotherapy, where waits rose by 5.6 days. Waits rose at 10 of 12 clinics.
- However, March was within the normal range of the last 18 months (16.5 to 18.3 days), and April fell back to 17.2 days.

**Possible Drivers**

- Total demand rose by about 4% (757 → 788 appointments), which may have put pressure on clinic capacity.
- The sharp rise in Physiotherapy waits (+5.6 days) suggests a possible capacity issue in that service.

**Limitations**

- The data does not include an urgent/routine flag, so we cannot tell whether the mix of cases changed.
- There is no staffing data, so we cannot confirm whether fewer staff were available.
- Waits are measured from booking, not referral, and the 48-day target is an assumption.

**Recommended Actions**

- Review Physiotherapy capacity: the Physiotherapy lead should review March staff availability and appointment slots within two weeks, because Physiotherapy had the biggest rise in waits (+5.6 days).
- Monitor before making major changes: the Operations Director should monitor waiting times weekly for the next three months, because March was within the normal range and April fell back to 17.2 days.
- Improve the data: the Data/BI team should start recording an urgent/routine flag and staffing levels from next month, so the cause of future changes can be confirmed.

**Metrics to Monitor**

- Average and median waiting days: weekly (red if the average goes above 20 days).
- SLA breach rate: weekly (red above 4%; March was 4.2%).
- Physiotherapy average wait: weekly, for the next three months (March was 21.2 days).
- Total appointments: monthly (red if it changes by more than 10% from the previous month).